

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS

Membership Recruitment Pocket Guide

Love • Wisdom • Harmony • Truth

YOUR GOAL

Recruitment is not about selling.

Your job is to:

Meet → Talk → Listen → Share → Invite → Follow Up → Ask

Focus on building a relationship first.

WHO SHOULD YOU LOOK FOR?

Think of people who value:

- friendship and fellowship;
- personal growth;
- community service;
- history and tradition;
- gardening or nature;
- symbolism and philosophy;
- learning and self-improvement.

Ask yourself:

Would this person be a positive addition to lodge life?

THE FIVE-NAME CHALLENGE

Write down five people you know who might enjoy learning about the Order.

Do not ask:

“Who can I get to join?”

Ask:

“Who should I introduce to Free Gardener?”

SIMPLE ELEVATOR PITCHES

10 Seconds

“The Free Gardeners are a historic fraternity focused on friendship, personal growth, service, and using gardening as a symbol for cultivating a better life.”

20 Seconds

“The Ancient Order of Free Gardeners is a centuries-old fraternal tradition. We use gardening as a symbol for personal growth while building friendships, learning together, and serving our communities.”

Curiosity Pitch

“Imagine a historic fraternity where gardening tools and traditions are used to teach lessons about life and character. That’s basically Free Gardenerly.”

EASY CONVERSATION STARTER

If someone asks about your emblem, shirt, pin, or organization:

“It belongs to the Ancient Order of Free Gardeners. We’re a historic fraternity that uses gardening as a symbol for personal growth, fellowship, and service.”

Then ask:

“Have you ever heard of the Free Gardeners before?”

Let the conversation develop naturally.

THE BEST RECRUITMENT QUESTION

Do not immediately ask:

“Do you want to join?”

Instead ask:

“Would you be interested in learning more?”

Then invite them to an event, coffee, service project, or the AOFG website.

SIX TALKING POINTS

When someone asks about the Order, remember:

HISTORY

Our tradition reaches back to seventeenth-century Scotland.

PERSONAL GROWTH

Gardening symbolizes cultivating one's character and life.

FELLOWSHIP

Members build meaningful friendships through lodge life.

EDUCATION

Members learn through lectures, discussion, history, and symbolism.

SERVICE

Members support gardens, conservation, beautification, and community improvement.

TRADITION

Degrees, ceremonies, and symbols connect members with generations of Free Gardeners.

OUR FOUR PRINCIPLES

Love — Care for others.

Wisdom — Continue learning.

Harmony — Work peacefully with others.

Truth — Live with integrity.

EASY RECRUITMENT TOOLS

Carry or display:

- AOFG business cards;
- QR code;
- small membership brochures;
- event flyers;
- AOFG shirts or pins;
- website information.

Recommended Business Card Message

ANCIENT ORDER OF FREE GARDENERS

Cultivate Yourself. Cultivate Community.

Fellowship • Personal Growth • Service • Tradition

Scan to Learn More

www.thefreegardeners.org

BEST PLACES TO MEET POTENTIAL MEMBERS

Look for opportunities at:

- community gardens;
- volunteer projects;
- farmers markets;
- garden shows;
- libraries;
- historical societies;
- conservation events;
- civic organizations;
- community festivals;
- neighborhood events;
- educational programs.

SIMPLE RECRUITMENT EVENTS

Keep events relaxed and inexpensive.

Try:

Coffee With the Free Gardeners

Meet casually at a coffee shop.

Meet the Free Gardeners

Host a short public information night.

Community Garden Day

Invite guests to work alongside members.

Garden & Grow Workshop

Teach a simple gardening topic.

History of the Free Gardeners

Give a public historical presentation.

Bring a Friend Night

Ask members to bring one guest.

Virtual Information Night

Host “What Is Free Gardener?” online.

ONE-HOUR INFORMATION NIGHT

10 Minutes

Welcome and casual conversation.

10 Minutes

Explain the history and purpose of the Order.

10 Minutes

Members share why they joined.

10 Minutes

Explain lodge life, service, fellowship, and degrees.

15 Minutes

Questions and conversation.

5 Minutes

Invite guests to learn more.

Say:

“If what you’ve heard interests you, we’d be happy to continue the conversation. There is no pressure. We simply invite you to explore whether Free Gardener might be right for you.”

ASK QUESTIONS

Good recruiters listen.

Ask:

“What kinds of organizations are you involved with?”

“What do you enjoy doing in the community?”

“What interests you most about what I’ve told you?”

“What would you look for in an organization like this?”

FOLLOW UP

Do not lose interested people because nobody contacted them.

Try to follow up within **48 hours**.

Example:

“Hi James, I enjoyed talking with you at the garden project Saturday. Thanks for spending some time with us. If you have any questions about the Free Gardeners, feel free to reach out.”

Keep it friendly.

Do not immediately ask if they have decided to join.

SIMPLE FOLLOW-UP PLAN

FIRST

Thank them for attending.

SECOND

Share something connected to their interests.

THIRD

Invite them to another event.

FOURTH

If their interest continues, explain the application process.

WHEN TO INVITE SOMEONE TO APPLY

After they have had time to learn about the Order, say:

“You’ve had a chance to get to know us, and we’ve enjoyed getting to know you. I think you could be a good addition to the lodge. If you’re interested, I’d be happy to explain how to apply.”

WHAT NOT TO DO

Never:

- pressure someone;
- argue with someone who declines;
- promise admission;
- exaggerate membership benefits;
- hide costs or responsibilities;
- insult other organizations;
- reveal private ritual information;
- make secrecy the main attraction;
- recruit only to increase numbers;
- repeatedly contact someone who is not interested.

THE RECRUITER'S POCKET METHOD

FIND

Identify someone who may share our values.

TALK

Start a normal conversation.

LISTEN

Learn about them.

SHARE

Explain what Free Gardenerly means to you.

INVITE

Bring them to an event.

FOLLOW UP

Stay connected.

ASK

When appropriate, invite them to apply.

ONE MEMBER — ONE NEW MEMBER

A simple annual goal:

Introduce at least one qualified person each year to Free Gardenery.

You do not have to recruit everyone.

You only have to help the right people discover that the Order exists.

REMEMBER

People join people before they join organizations.

Be welcoming.

Be genuine.

Be active.

Tell your story.

Extend the invitation.

Plant the seed.

Cultivate the Individual.

Cultivate the Lodge.

Cultivate the Community.

www.thefreegardeners.org